

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

# Customer Success English

## Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

### PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For customer success managers, account managers, onboarding specialists, support escalation leads, renewals managers, implementation teams, and post-sale revenue leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

# Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

## Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

## Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

# Field vocabulary A-Z

**adoption**

The extent to which people begin and continue using a product or process.

**boundary**

A limit on acceptable conduct, responsibility, access, or scope.

**business outcome**

A result the organization wants to achieve through its work.

**churn risk**

The possibility that a customer will stop using or renewing a service.

**commercial term**

A business condition of an agreement, such as price, quantity, or payment timing.

**commitment**

An explicit promise or accepted responsibility to do something.

**customer owner**

The person on the customer's side responsible for coordinating an agreed activity.

**escalation**

Raising an issue to a higher authority or different function because risk, urgency, or decision rights require it.

**executive escalation**

Referring an unresolved issue to senior leadership for attention or a decision.

**executive sponsor**

A senior person who supports an initiative and helps resolve major organizational issues.

**expansion**

An increase in the scope or size of a customer relationship or business activity.

**expectation setting**

Clarifying what can be delivered, under which conditions, and by when.

**feature request**

A proposal for new or changed product functionality.

**go-live**

The point at which a system or service begins its intended operational use.

**health score**

A defined summary indicator used to assess the state of a customer account.

**implementation**

Putting an agreed plan, product, or process into operation.

**onboarding**

The process of helping a new employee or customer begin effectively.

**product feedback**

Information from users or stakeholders about how a product meets their needs.

**QBR**

Quarterly business review: a periodic customer discussion of results, priorities, and next steps.

**readiness**

The degree to which required conditions for an activity have been met.

**renewal**

Continuation of a policy, contract, or subscription for a further period.

**roadmap**

A plan showing intended product or organizational direction over time, with varying levels of commitment.

**ROI**

Return on investment: a measure comparing a defined net benefit with investment cost; state the calculation and assumptions.

**severity**

The seriousness of an event, impact, or loss under stated criteria.

**SLA**

Service-level agreement defining expected service performance or response commitments.

**stakeholder engagement**

The involvement and interaction of people affected by an activity or decision.

**upsell**

Offering a customer a higher-value version or additional paid capability.

**usage**

Observed use of a product or service under a defined measurement.

**use case**

A specific situation describing how someone uses a product or service to achieve a goal.

**value gap**

The difference between the value a customer expects and the value they experience.

**workaround**

A temporary alternative that allows a task to continue while the underlying issue remains.

# Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

## Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

## Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means ... .

The difference is that ... .

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

## Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is ... .

The next update will cover ... .

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

## Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

## Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ... .

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

## Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but ... .

Option A ..., whereas option B ... .

The comparison depends on ... .

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

## Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for ... . The correct information is ... .

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses ... .

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

# Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

## 01 | Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

A customer expects to go live next Friday, but data migration responsibilities and training dates are still unassigned.

What needs to be complete for you to consider the launch ready? Let's confirm the migration owner and training dates before treating next Friday as a committed go-live date.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

## 02 | Adoption Metrics and Health Scores

An account has many logins but little use of the workflow it purchased the product to improve.

Logins show activity, but they do not tell us whether the intended workflow is being adopted. Let's review the relevant usage and ask the customer about the outcome they are trying to achieve.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

## 03 | Support Escalations and Incident Communication

A customer issue has a verified workaround but no confirmed permanent-fix date. A draft update promises a fix tomorrow.

We have a verified workaround, but the permanent-fix date is not confirmed. I'll explain the workaround and state the next update time without promising an unverified resolution date.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.



## 04 | QBRs and Business Outcomes

A business review claims a large return on investment using estimated time savings that the customer has not validated.

The return estimate depends on unverified time-saving assumptions. Let's review those assumptions with the customer and label the result as an estimate rather than a demonstrated outcome.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

## 05 | Renewals and Churn Risk

An account renews in six weeks. The main contact has changed, and the team has not confirmed current priorities.

Could we arrange a review with the current decision makers to confirm priorities and unresolved issues? That will help us understand the renewal discussion before assuming the previous plan still fits.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

## 06 | Expansion and Upsell Ethics

A customer is considering more licenses while many existing users have not completed onboarding.

Additional licenses may be useful, but adoption of the current ones is still incomplete. Let's compare expansion with improving onboarding against the customer's immediate goals before recommending the next purchase.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

## 07 | Product Feedback and Feature Requests

A customer asks for a specific feature, but the product team needs to understand the underlying workflow and current obstacle.

What task are you trying to complete, and what prevents you from doing it today? I'll record the workflow and impact so the product team can evaluate the request without treating a proposed feature as the only solution.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

## 08 | Difficult Customers and Boundary Setting

A frustrated customer says a feature was promised for this month. The record contains an estimate, not a confirmed commitment.

I understand why you expected it this month. The earlier wording did not clearly distinguish an estimate from a commitment. I'll clarify the current status and discuss the available options with the responsible team.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

# Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

## Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

## Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

### Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

### Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

## Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

# Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

## Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

## Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

## Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

## Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

# Build vocabulary and collocations

## START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

## REFERENCE

Course: Customer Success English

Professional audience: customer success managers, account managers, onboarding specialists, support escalation leads, renewals managers, implementation teams, and post-sale revenue leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

Original fictional case: A customer expects to go live next Friday, but data migration responsibilities and training dates are still unassigned.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Vocabulary: onboarding: The process of helping a new employee or customer begin effectively. / go-live: The point at which a system or service begins its intended operational use. / implementation: Putting an agreed plan, product, or process into operation. / customer owner: The person on the customer's side responsible for coordinating an agreed activity.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and

an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What needs to be complete for you to consider the launch ready? Let's confirm the migration owner and training dates before treating next Friday as a committed go-live date.

**END REFERENCE**

**TASK:** Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

**END PROMPT**

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

# Test recall and transfer

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Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

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#### END REFERENCE

TASK: A short retrieval session

1. Tell me to close my notes. Plan six questions: two vocabulary-in-context items, one grammar or meaning contrast, one question about a confirmed versus unknown detail, one short spoken-style response and one new-situation transfer task. Use the supplied material as the answer reference, but do not repeat its existing checks word for word.
2. Ask only the first question, then stop and wait. Prefer a short answer over a multiple-choice question. Do not display the remaining questions, model answers or a word bank in advance.
3. After each answer, say what it gets right and explain a meaningful error if there is one. Accept alternative wording when it preserves the facts and does the communication job. If I struggle, give one clue and invite a retry before revealing a model. Only then move to the next question.
4. Keep a simple record of which items I answered independently, with a hint, or after seeing a model. This records today's practice, not a certified proficiency score. Do not judge pronunciation from typed text.
5. At the end, summarize two strengths and two useful next steps with examples from my answers. Give me a small review card containing three prompts and a separate answer section. Suggest that I revisit it tomorrow and a week later; do not claim you will remember this session or send reminders. Label the final transfer scenario as fictional.

#### END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level